

Securing car-centric cities:

An ecological reconstruction of ‘Designing out crime’

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Abstract

What can we learn about urban crime and disorder by ‘following’ the car and its infrastructural supports? In this paper, we address this question via an ecological critique and reconstruction of the ‘crime prevention through environmental design’ (CPTED) movement. We first describe the ways in which cities across the Global North were reimagined and rebuilt for cars during mid-20th century and consider the direct and indirect effects this auto-centric city making had on crime and disorder. We then identify the ways in which the framers of CPTED overlooked the impact of automobility on urban life and danger, before analysing how contemporary exponents of ‘designing out crime’ have taken against urban proximity by focusing on property crime at the expense of car-generated crime and disorder and the wider provisioning of viable neighbourhoods. CPTED has, we suggest, been an agent in the formation and securing of car-centric cities. We then seek to critically reconfigure the aspiration to ‘design’ out crime in ways that encompass the mundane harms of auto-centric mobility systems, and attend to the active role that socio-material infrastructures can play in fashioning both safe and liveable urban environments under conditions of climate breakdown.

Keywords

Automobility; crime prevention; environmental criminology; infrastructure; roads; urban design

Introduction

What can we learn about urban crime and disorder by ‘following’ the car? Have urban environments built to prioritize the efficient flow of motorized traffic contributed to criminal harm, either directly or indirectly? If so, how? In this paper, we address these questions by means of an ecological critique and reconstruction of environmental criminology and the crime prevention through environmental design movement (CPTED). In so doing, we trace discursively how protagonists in the CPTED movement selectively took up the impact of automobility on urban life and danger, seeking to ‘design out crime’ in ways focused on property crime at the expense of car-generated crime and disorder, and the wider provisioning of viable neighbourhoods. CPTED has, as a result, been an agent in the formation and securing of car-centric cities. We then seek to critically reconfigure the aspiration to ‘design’ out crime in ways that encompass the mundane harms of auto-centric mobility systems, and attend to the active role that socio-material infrastructures can play in fashioning both safe and liveable urban environments under conditions of climate breakdown.

Two further arguments are threaded through the paper. First, we problematize the sharp distinction that CPTED proponents tend to make between ‘safe’ and ‘good’ or ‘sustainable’ urban environments, and their narrow prioritization of the former over the latter. The hostility that environmental criminologists display towards proponents of ‘liveable’ neighbourhoods is both puzzling and misplaced, as we shall show. Under conditions of profound ecological mutation, that opposition, and its false oppositions, are literally unsustainable. Second, we take up and extend the key organizing insight of CPTED: namely, that built environments matter when it comes to everyday safety. We seek to extend that insight by playing fuller attention to the role of objects and infrastructure as constitutive agents in shaping the (safe/good) city, thereby bringing criminology into closer dialogue with the social analysis of infrastructure and material culture. It is with such questions that we begin.

Designing in crime? Making cities safe for cars

Urban life is constituted by and mediated through infrastructure. Infrastructure is ‘matter that enables the movement of other matter’ (Larkin 2013: 329). It comprises built networks – roads, pipes, cables and the like – ‘that facilitate the flow of goods, people, or ideas and allows for their exchange over space’. It is the socio-technical architecture of circulation. It generates the ‘ambient environment of everyday life’ (ibid.). Infrastructures are embedded, sunk into other structures and social arrangements, installed on the sedimentary layers of past infrastructural projects. They are ever-present, but also absent: typically becoming visible, or getting noticed, only when they break, or fall into disrepair, or become obstructed (Star 1999). But infrastructure is never merely the dull, silent backdrop to the drama of human life and conflict. To attend to infrastructure is to access the more-than-human character of the worlds we are trying to understand, to replace the human as the privileged epistemic subject and grasp urban life through a distributed notion of agency (Buier 2023: 49). Infrastructure is not inert but, as Amin (2014) puts it, ‘lively’. It is a formative part of cities that need to be understood as a mangle of machines, networks, humans, nonhumans, matter and nature (Amin and Thrift 2017: 9) – the city as an ‘infrastructural entanglement with considerable agency’ (ibid.: 33-34). Nor are infrastructures neutral. They are sites and products of political power. They reveal political rationalities. Infrastructures supply affordances for some modes of being, acting and moving, while hindering or foreclosing others. They are the foundation of social practice – enabling and constraining, facilitating and blocking, the generative condition of possibility and impossibility, well-being and sustainability, in everyday life (Corchia and Borghini 2025). If we are to make the ‘imbrication of infrastructure and human organization’ the starting point for enquiring into urban life and danger, as Star (1999: 379) suggests, we need to ask: What forms of human and human-material interaction are buried in the design and infrastructure of cities? What

values, what principles of social ordering, and what hierarchies, does it install? (see, generally, Tomkin 2013).

If, as Star argues, infrastructure has a ‘master narrative’, a ‘voice that speaks unconsciously from the presumed center of things (Star 1989: 384), then across most cities of the Global North the organizing voice is that of motorized vehicles, especially cars. The physical infrastructure of modern urban environments has during the past century been re-fashioned to prioritize the speedy, efficient flow of private cars, first across the US and Global North, latterly if unevenly across cities in the Global South (Gopukumar 2020). Norton (2008) recounts the bitter battles that broke out across US cities in the 1920s over the use and meaning of city streets, which had till then hosted an array of practices and mobilities. As car ownership spread beyond elites, battle waged between the interests of pedestrians, anxious parents, police, traffic engineers, and the newly—formed alliance of motoring interests (what Norton terms ‘Motordom’) over competing ideologies of safety, order, efficiency and freedom. By 1930, Norton shows, Motordom had largely triumphed in its battle over the meaning and allocation of urban space. As ‘rhetorical closure’ was affected over the conflict, a ‘new kind of city emerged’ and a new kind of urban disposition had taken shape. It was a city that had been designed and disciplined to satisfy the ‘needs of motorists’ (ibid.: 7).

Cognate battles resurfaced in the 1950s and 1960s, as the car became a mass consumer object and symbol of aspiration, prosperity, status and freedom. The Interstate Highways Act 1956 triggered a road building programme that entrenched the place of the car in American life and further transformed its cities. It did so in ways that flattened, disfigured or disorganised poor Black neighbourhoods, while cementing racial segregation in the built environment (Lewis 2013, Archer 2020). The new highway network also underpinned the movement of millions of fearful white residents who materially and ideologically abandoned US urban centres for sprawling, low-density suburbs (Kruse 2005; Henderson 2006). In Simmel’s (1994) terms, highway infrastructure offered a ‘bridge’ out of the city for middle-class whites and Blacks, while erecting ‘doors’ within and between the disadvantaged neighbourhoods of those left behind. But this is not simply an American tale. In the face of the seemingly inevitable tide of rising car ownership, city after city across the Global North was remodelled to suit the interests and convenience of the car (Buchanan 1963; Klemek 2011; Gunn and Townsend 2021). Cities became habitats whose built infrastructure was reconstructed with ramps, bypasses, tunnels, expressways and roundabouts and where the mundane experience of all urbanites (drivers and nondrivers alike) was to become inseparable from the ‘flexible coercion’ wrought by the dominance of automobility (Sheller and Urry 2000). Motorized traffic became constitutive of the urban condition. Cities had been made safe for cars.

An adequate account of social life and relations in cities in general, and urban crime and disorder in particular, has to reckon with this foundational fact. Criminology has highlighted various relevant consequences of the automotive transformation of (American) cities. Cars have been acknowledged as an active agent in the extended

mobility of offenders and offending, spreading ‘big city problems’ to smaller towns and rural areas (Headworth 2023: 87). The mass ownership of automobiles in the decades after 1945 created millions of valuable and portable objects, the theft of which contributed enormously to the exponential rise in volume crime from the 1960s to the mid-1990s (Garland 2001; Felson and Boba 2010). The subsequent crime drop has been a consequence in significant measure of ongoing (though only partially successful) efforts to make cars more difficult to steal (Farrell et al. 2011). Suburban sprawl was an indirect cause of property crime becoming ‘a prominent fact of modern life’ (Garland 2001: 106) during the latter third of the twentieth century: by separating where people lived from where they worked, suburbs became collections of homes containing ‘suitable targets’ in relatively empty neighbourhoods lacking ‘capable guardianship’ (Felson and Boba 2010; Singer and Drakulich 2019). Sporadic attention has also been paid to the ways in which highway construction ‘produced isolation and immiseration in the neighbourhoods they cut through’ (Headworth 2023: 80), with concentrating effects upon levels of poverty, property crime and violence (Kim and Hipp 2018; McCutcheon et al. 2016; McCutcheon 2021). Marshall Berman’s (1982: 290-299) analysis of the impact on local neighbourhood life of Robert Moses’ Cross-Bronx Expressway offers an evocative case-in-point of highway-induced social disorganization.

It is an often-overlooked detail of Wilson and Kelling’s (1982) influential – and notorious – account of urban disorder that the eponymous ‘Broken Window’ is a car window. The neglect of this small fact is telling. For the most part, auto-dominance and its infrastructures are taken-for-granted in research on collective efficacy, urban disorder and fear of crime. They are treated as the immutable backdrop against which crime and disorder play out (something so buried in our sense of the city that we barely notice it), rather than active causal agents in the process of creating motivations or opportunities for crime, or disrupting or destroying the conditions of possibility for informal social control and community cohesion, or generating urban anxieties (cf. Hunter and Baumer 1982). Robert Sampson’s longitudinal study of neighbourhood effects in Chicago has little to say about the impact of the motor age on the social life of the city (Sampson 2012).¹ A recent textbook on *Urban Criminology* contains not a single index entry to ‘cars’, or ‘infrastructure’ or ‘road traffic’ (Atkinson and Millington 2019). The car and its infrastructural supports have remained a curious blind spot in social disorganization and related theories of urban crime.

¹ For a partial exception see Sampson and Levy (2022) – though this paper is focused on the criminogenic effects of everyday urban mobility, not so much on *how* people move and its impact on neighbourhood life. Much the same holds for Browning et al.’s (2021: 100) call to acknowledge ‘the often submerged assumptions regarding mobility embedded in several prominent criminological theories’. Their subsequent analysis of social disorganization, collective efficacy and urban disorder theories collapses different forms of movement – walking, cycling, driving – into the singular category of ‘mobility’ in ways that are analytically unhelpful.

Environmental criminology and the crime prevention through environmental design movement stand as partial exceptions in this regard. CPTED grasps the importance of physical infrastructure in creating or mitigating opportunities for crime, and for embedding informal surveillance in the routines of everyday life. It is, in fact, its animating insight. That recognition has been partial, however, due to systemic inattention to the forms of criminal harm and social disorder directly created by mass motoring, and the indirect effects of car-centric mobility systems on the environments in which criminal activity and informal social control take place. CPTED practitioners have also become active protagonists in contestation over the forms, meanings and use of public space in ways that have unduly separated ‘safety’ from ‘sustainability’ and privileged the former in ways that are, under conditions of ecological breakdown, rendered untenable. So, it is worth spending some time reconstructing and appraising the key claims.

Car harms and designing out crime: Or, did no one read Chapter 18?

The framing ambition of environmental criminology has been to focus attention on ‘the ways in which the structure of the urban environment can be used to control and prevent crime’ (Jeffrey 1971: 215). In the book that launched a crime prevention movement, Jeffrey argued that such environments can influence criminal behaviour – and behaviour in general - in one of two ways: ‘physically, by providing the physical surroundings to which individuals respond; and socially, by providing the social relationship to which individuals respond’ (ibid.). Cities, Jeffrey intriguingly suggests, ‘can be designed so as to increase human contact of an intimate nature. Anomie, loneliness and alienation need not characterise urban life’ (ibid.: 225). In his view:

Streets which have pedestrian *and vehicular traffic*, which have small shops and cafes open late at night, and which have residents living in apartments overlooking the street level are safe streets. (ibid.: 216; emphasis added)

The fullest original articulation of these ideas came in Oscar Newman’s (1971) *Defensible Space*. Newman was an architect interested in the design of, and spatial relation between, buildings. His focus lay in how physical design enables or hinders the ability of communities ‘to come together in joint action’ – what later came to be known as collective efficacy (Sampson et al. 1997). The particular target of Newman’s ire – and subsequent interventions – was high-rise public housing projects, which he claimed had prevented ‘such amity and discouraged the natural pursuit of collective action’ (ibid: 2) by creating anonymous, unloved, hard to supervise and neglected public spaces (see, on the UK case, Coleman 1985). Newman’s response was to (re)model the physical fabric of residential environments to enable them to inhibit crime. Defensible space describes ‘an environment in which the latent territoriality and sense of community of inhabitants can

be translated into responsibility for ensuring a safe, productive and well-maintained living space.’ (ibid.: 3) The potential criminal perceives such space as controlled by residents. Defensible space is comprised of a range of mechanisms - real and symbolic barriers, strongly defined areas of influence, and improved opportunities for formal and informal surveillance – that combine to bring an environment under the control of its residents. The ambition is to ‘create areas for which people will adopt concern, create conditions for mutual support’ (ibid.: 2024). Newman too had things to say about the properties of safe streets:

streets provide security in the form of prominent paths for concentrated pedestrian and vehicular movements; windows and doorways, when facing streets, extend the zone of residents’ territorial commitments and allow for the continual surveillance of police in passing cars. Jane Jacobs in her *Death and Life of Great American Cities* contends that surveillance provided by causal passersby on foot or in a car is important as a deterrent to criminal activity. (1971: 25; emphasis added)

Jane Jacobs (1961) is frequently cited as inspiration for the CPTED movement. But she did *not* – at least in full – make the contention that Jeffrey draws from her work and that Newman explicitly attributes to her. As we shall see, the part that they erroneously presume to be present – vehicular surveillance – matters. In fact, it matters a lot. Jacobs describes streets and sidewalks, the main public spaces of a city, as its most vital organs (see also Pollack 2026). They are also the key to urban safety, understood as how to be and feel secure among strangers. For Jacobs, famously, ‘the first thing to understand is that public peace of cities is not kept primarily by the police, necessary as police are. It is kept primarily by an intricate, almost unconscious network of voluntary controls and standards among the people themselves and enforced by the people themselves. . . No amount of police can enforce civilization when the normal, casual enforcement of it has broken down’ (1961: 31-2.). The ingredients for the intricate ‘ballet’ of social control are a clear demarcation of public and private space; eyes on the street belonging to its natural proprietors; and facilities that draw a diversity of users to the street on a fairly consistent basis (ibid: 46-7). These ingredients are destroyed if one tries to solve the problem of urban insecurity by spreading people and urban life out thinly. ‘A well-used street’, Jacobs (ibid.: 44) contends, ‘is apt to be a safe street’.

Jacobs believes that ‘we blame automobiles too much’ (ibid.: 353); their damaging effects are less a cause than a symptom of the failure to design workable cities. But – in Chapter 18 of *Death and Life* – she nonetheless contends that the constitutive elements of the system of automobility – ‘traffic arteries, parking lots, filling stations and so on’ (ibid. 352) – are ‘powerful instruments of city destruction’ resulting in city streets being ‘broken down into loose sprawls, incoherent and vacuous for anyone on foot’ (ibid.: 352). The problem, for Jacobs, is ‘the overwhelming numbers of vehicles, to which the most minimum pedestrian needs are gradually and steadily sacrificed’ (ibid: 359). Cities, as a result, face a key question: ‘erosion of cities by automobiles, or attrition of automobiles by cities’ (ibid.: 363).

Erosion, Jacobs suggests, is a slow, barely discernible process. Cars start nibbling away at urban space; they sometimes take hefty bites. As, over time, more space is given over to enable cars to be moved or stored, the greater becomes the need for cars, hence more space is needed. Public transport is trimmed back or removed, creating yet more demand for cars. The cumulative effect is enormous, and is described by Jacobs in ways that provide a contender to 'Broken windows'-influenced accounts of the spiral of urban decline and disorder: 'erosion, little by little, subtracts reasons for using the eroded district, and at the same time makes it less lively, less compact, less safe for those who continue to have reason to use it' (ibid.: 365). The process proceeds, she continues, with no stopping off point, becoming genuinely harder to halt or reverse. Efforts towards reversal require what Jacobs calls 'tactics of attrition', small acts of taking back (ibid.: 377). These seek to make conditions 'less convenient for cars' (ibid.: 377), gradually seeking to reduce the number of people using private vehicles. Jacobs identifies several such acts: increasing the size of sidewalks, installing public parklets into urban space, using bollards to stop traffic overspill from arteries, and protect the localized use of streets. There are good reasons to believe that she considered these in part to be crime prevention measures.

Jane Jacobs is routinely lauded – with this or that qualification – as inspiration for the CPTED movement. Yet there is little to suggest that Jeffrey, Newman or their many successors either read Chapter 18 of *Death and Life* or, if they did, considered it relevant to criminological work. The effects of this oversight are evident from the get-go. They are, as intimated, discernible in the way Jeffrey and Newman collapse pedestrian and motorized surveillance and insist that relevant eyes-on-the-street can be those of passing motorists: 'vehicular access provides', Newman (1971: 60) writes, 'a form of continuous natural surveillance'. This is an unannounced and barely noticed break with Jacobs.² It more importantly overlooks the phenomenology of driving (Randell 2017): the speed and shell of the car cocoons its driver from the sounds, feel and rhythms of the street, rendering them a poor observer of its interactional order (and dangers). Such insulated movement renders informal surveillance close to impossible.³ Expecting drivers to attend to the social life of sidewalks also distracts them from the task at hand: navigating a large

² It is a fair bet that neither Jeffrey nor Newman even noticed this slippage. It may simply have been the result of the auto-centric world in which they lived and worked, of which they were barely conscious.

³ An intriguing contrast can be drawn here with gated communities. Newman (1971: 14) was a critic of middle-class gated living, which he derided as 'high-rise fortresses of semi-luxury'. His objection was that such living gave rise to 'introversion and intentional isolation' that has three 'dangerous characteristics' (ibid.): indifference to the crime problem once it has been evaded; relegation of security to formal security alone, and achieving security at the expense of the adjacent area. 'A natural mechanism providing safety to our streets', Newman (1971: 15) writes, 'has been sacrificed to ensure the security of the walled-off complex'. It is worth asking how much of this analysis can be extended to the insulated and isolating movement offered by cars. Jane Jacobs (1961: 56) is clear that 'taking refuge in vehicles' is one technique people adopt in the absence of urban safety, an avoidance strategy that reproduces the conditions that give rise to urban danger in the first place. She places cocooned private mobility in the same vein here as 'cultivation of a turf, or gated living'.

steel machine through busy – and fleshy – urban environments. It is hard not to see this claim as an instance of public safety being mentally separated from road safety and pursued at the latter's expense (cf. Loader 2026).

A further consequence of this collapsing of modes of movement is a failure to register the way in which heavy car traffic indirectly contributes to crime and disorder by damaging the landscapes of, and conditions of possibility for, informal social control and community efficacy. One dimension of this relates to how cars insulate likely offenders from their surroundings, making easy identification by residents difficult. But car traffic also interrupts the capacity of residents to develop Newman's preferred sense of proprietorial rights and willingness to engage in natural surveillance and amity-building in their living space. This much became clear from a parallel literature on urban environments initiated at the time that Jeffrey and Newman were writing. For example, in their study of the effects of traffic on the quality of social interaction on city streets, Appleyard and Lintell (1972) show that residents on the 'heavy traffic' street they studied in San Francisco made no clear demarcation between public space and local territory that was their responsibility. There was, moreover, little or no sidewalk activity and sense of community, and residents failed to notice and remember details of the environment around them. 'Heavy traffic' was, in short, 'associated with withdrawal from the physical environment' and social interaction beyond the home (ibid.: 97). We can only speculate as to how the history of CPTED would have unfolded if it had from the outset taken account of the growing body of literature on the environmental impact of road traffic (see also, Appleyard 1981; Bosselmann and O'Hare 1983; Hart and Parkhurst 2011).⁴ Might such encounters have generated an altered – perhaps radically different – sense of what it means to create 'physical design that enables residents to control their environment rather than become its victims' (Newman 1971: 8)?

Neglecting to attend to the car's impact on urban environments also lead the pioneers of CPTED to overlook the direct criminogenic effects of car-centricity on urban safety: road crime. Car-heavy cities are landscapes of mass law-breaking and criminal harm, albeit often committed by offenders who understand themselves to be law-abiding. They are environments in which drivers routinely exceed speed limits, move carelessly or recklessly, or while impaired by drink or drugs, or (nowadays) distracted by mobile phones. They are environments in which humans are killed or seriously injured in acts of road violence, in ways marked by significant socio-spatial disparities, as are countless numbers of non-human animals.⁵ They are places beset by the harms of

⁴ It should be noted that in some of his subsequent crime prevention interventions Newman came to see the value of reducing cut-through traffic and implicitly acknowledged that heavy car movement erodes territoriality in the affected neighbourhoods and leaves them more exposed to crime (see Newman 1996).

⁵ In 1971, the year *Defensible Space* was published, there were 54,700 motor vehicle traffic deaths in the United States. The year marked a period when highway fatalities in the US were at historic highs; https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Motor_vehicle_fatality_rate_in_U.S._by_year. In the same year, there were 17,730 reported homicides.

congestion, noise and air pollution (Kay and Moore 2025; Loader 2026). None of this criminal harm merits a mention in the framing texts of Jeffrey and Newman. What, we are left wondering, would have happened to the analysis and prescription if road crime, and the socio-spatial patterning of serious injury, death and environmental despoliation, had been present at the outset and formed part of the ensuing urban safety conversation? At the very least, Newman (1971: 204) would have found it more difficult to characterize *Defensible Space* in these terms: ‘the areas most usually identified as safe are heavily trafficked public streets and arteries combining both intense vehicular traffic and pedestrian movement’.

Safety first? The curious criminological war on urban proximity

The CPTED movement has mushroomed in the decades since Jeffrey and Newman made their framing contributions. It now encompasses academics working internationally across environmental criminology, routine activities and rational choice theory, and with close affiliations to situational crime prevention (Schneider and Kitchen 2007). It extends to committed practitioners in police, crime prevention and urban planning and in some jurisdictions has found institutional form, notably in the UK police’s *Secured by Design* programme launched in 1989.⁶ CPTED has evolved into self-styled ‘second’ and ‘third’ generations whose concerns seek to connect design to questions of social cohesion, community-building and liveability (Cleveland and Saville 1997; Mihinjac and Saville 2019; see also Cozens and Love 2015). It now operates largely in and upon cities that have been further transformed by processes of suburbanization and low-density living, urban forms that CPTED often seems eager to defend, as we shall see.

This expansion and diversification notwithstanding, CPTED has coalesced around some core claims. Foremost among these is a preference for enclosure, for ‘properties designed with minimum access/egress’ (Armitage 2013: 85). The attendant concern is that increased street activity heightens exposure to motivated offenders and provides those offenders with access points and escape routes, such that more enclosed, less permeable environments may ultimately be safer (Birks and Davies 2017). The consequent ambition – as stated in *Secured by Design* guidance – is for single-family, low-density, residential cul-de-sacs. Houses should also, on this view, be designed to accommodate vehicle parking, or laid out in ways that enable cars to be stored in view of adjacent housing. Permeability is cast here as creating opportunities for crime, while undermining possibilities for proprietorial oversight of public space and effective natural surveillance.⁷ For the most part, permeability means walking: the aim is to restrict street

⁶ <https://www.securedbydesign.com/about-us/about-sbd>

⁷ Though Newman is often cited and frequently lauded as laying for ground for such arguments, we have arguably travelled some way from his framing concerns. Environments are made safe on this

not road connectivity (cf. Crowe and Zahm 1994). In fact, road connectivity is necessary to render these forms of low-density settlement feasible. What is being described and secured is a form of living that depends upon, and bakes in, car-dependency.

This is the backdrop to the objections CPTED protagonists made to ‘New Urbanist’ planning. Two related forms of such planning are called out for attention here: the creation of ‘neo-traditional’ environments that use high-quality design features and lay-outs to foster social interaction and community;⁸ and forms of high-density, multiple use, compact neighbourhoods that seek to counter the economic, environmental, public health, and social ills of low-density, car-dependent urban forms (Southworth and Owens 1993). Though it has post-dated most of the active criticism levelled at New Urbanism, the most salient contemporary iteration of such ideas is the ‘15-minute city’, urban environments that make it easy for people to navigate by walking or cycling and bring basic provisioning within reasonable distance of people’s homes. Carlos Moreno – one of the key architects of the ‘15-minute city’ – couches them as a vital urban adaptations to climate breakdown, what he terms ‘the proximity revolution’ (Moreno, 2024).

The objection levelled at these ideas by proponents of CPTED is that the emphasis on sustainability and quality of life has come as the expense of public safety, which has been neglected (Town and O’Toole 2005). Worse, the contention goes, New Urbanist principles have generated forms of urban design that are actively criminogenic. ‘The crime prevention dimensions to this theory are limited’, Cozens (2008: 433) writes, ‘and lack both critical discussion and systematic evidence’ (see also Schneider and Kitchen 2007: 52). CPTED advocates charge that New Urbanism ‘overlook[s] 30 years research [that] has repeatedly found that permeability increases opportunities for crime’ (Cozens 2008: 434); ignores increased risks of damage to, and theft of cars, that are parked away from adjoining homes, and generates housing forms that increase the cost of policing (Knowles 2008; Armitage 2007). New urbanism, in short, promotes the very thing that modern proponents of CPTED believe urban design should seek to avoid: ‘greater levels of movement past the home are generally associated with higher degrees of risk’ (Armitage 2007: 88). The case prosecuted against New Urbanism is – in these terms – emphatically pressed. The CPTED prosecutors generally consider it to be closed.

Elsewhere, we have sought to re-open the case, and challenge the consensus portraying walkable neighbourhoods as criminogenic (Pina-Sanchez and Loader 2026). We did so by highlighting two key issues – one methodological, the other substantive – that have been overlooked by CPTED and environmental criminology more broadly. Our first critique concerns the adoption of crime counts as opposed to victimization risk as

(re)formulation of defensible space, not by the continuous flow of pedestrian movement, but by emptying streets of such movement. By insulating private property from the threats posed by outsiders, this sometimes feels more akin to a suburban variant of the gated living that Newman decried.

⁸ Perhaps the most well-known UK example is Poundbury, in Dorset: <https://www.ice.org.uk/what-is-civil-engineering/infrastructure-projects/poundbury>

the predominant outcome variable analysed in the literature, and, relatedly, the excessive emphasis placed on police-recorded property crime, residential burglary in particular (Birks and Davies 2017). This choice confounds human interaction with risk of victimization and inevitably points to the conclusion that more seclusion equals greater safety – in extremis, it implies that the only safe urban design is one composed of completely disconnected spaces. We then argue that enclosed habitats do not prevent but rather *increase* crime, elsewhere and in different forms. Specifically, low-density cul-de-sac neighbourhoods, the alleged safest type of urban design, deepen car-dependency which, in turn, leads to motoring offences and other forms of street crime across the road network. The importance of this second-order effect cannot be understated: in England & Wales, motoring offences have grown in number and proportion, accounting for 60% of all cases sentenced in 2024. They consume more criminal justice resources than any other crime type. Yet, they have long been – and remain – curiously overlooked in CPTED research on urban safety.

On these grounds, we sought to make the case that walkability is *for* crime prevention. But there is also value in seeking to protect walkability *from* crime prevention, or at least insisting upon a more holistic – or ecological – appraisal of the properties that make neighbourhoods safe and those that make them liveable or sustainable in other ways, and of the relation between them. The protagonists of CPTED have in the main neither attempted still less accomplished such appraisal. Some have gestured in the direction of ‘balancing sustainability and security’ (Cozens and Love 2009: 348) or else wished the tension away by suggestion that ‘the elements that make a neighbourhood safe are the same elements that make a “good” neighbourhood’ (Crowe and Zahm 1994: 22). Others have worried about a possible ‘dark side’ of CPTED in terms of ‘extreme target hardening, overfortification and exclusionary methods’ (Cozens 2017: 2). But for the most part, proponents of CPTED draw a sharp distinction between ‘safe’ and ‘liveable’ or ‘sustainable’ neighbourhoods, before focussing on, and affording priority to, the former over the latter. They tend to proceed wielding (property) crime prevention as some kind of trump card, thereby giving the control of burglary and vehicle crime privileged status in contests over how to design and sustain ‘viable’ neighbourhoods and ‘the good city’ (Amin 2016). These moves rest, as we have sought to show, on systematic neglect of the criminal harms directly and indirectly created by the forms of low-density, car-dependent living to which CPTED has become attached. They also risk making crime risk the arbiter and enemy of the forms of provisioning that make neighbourhood’s nourishing places to inhabit (see, Harper 2022). It takes quite some criminological hubris to believe it legitimate to curtail the mundane – and in so many ways beneficial – practice of urban walking (and wheeling).

There is, in fact, something bafflingly antagonistic about the rearguard CPTED has put up against the ‘proximity revolution’. The antipathy can sometimes be detected in the passingly sneering tone of some among its authors, not merely chastising New Urbanism for its neglect of public safety, but disparaging ‘the dubious goal of reducing

auto-dependency' (Town and O'Toole 2005: 1) or placing 'sustainability' issues in scare quotes and dismissing New Urbanism's "slick" professional marketing and promotional campaigns' (Cozens 2008: 430). But it is more apparent in the one-way character of the engagement. New Urbanists are extolled to take the crime question seriously (like naughty school-children being brought into line), when they in fact take very seriously motoring offences, death and injury of the road and industrial levels of car-generated environmental harm, and seek pathways to combat them. That demand is pressed, however, with little or no sense that the direction of influence might also be reversed, that we need today to think and act on public safety in ways that consider, and are conditioned by, pressing ecological questions. Given the predilection of CPTED for evidence-based analysis and intervention, there may be value in its proponents appraising themselves of the evidence on Anthropogenic global warming and thinking through its possible implications for the design of safe urban neighbourhoods (See, Loader et al. 2026: ch. 6)

CPTED was forged in the midst of, and as response to, the post-1945 explosion in rates of volume property crime across the Global North which, to be fair, its practical proposals helped in part to stem (Farrell et al. 2011). It was a constitutive component of the 'culture of control' (Garland 2001). But while concerns about burglary and vehicle theft have not disappeared, they have abated, and co-exist today with a pressing mix of insecurities pertaining to the protection of personal safety, place and the wider planet (Loader et al. 2026). CPTED risks here looking like a legacy project, trapped in an 'old' ecology of security, and now seeking to orient itself amid a set of everyday (and broadly environmental) security concerns that its practitioners struggle to apprehend. In the face of such concerns, we may urgently need to adjust the operative sense of what is at stake when we design material and social infrastructures to inhibit crime and foster a sense of urban security, and recalibrate the relation between safety and liveability. There are grounds for thinking that the harms of car-centric mobility systems need to be at the heart of such recalibration.

Ecologizing safe neighbourhoods: Or, learning to love the humble bollard

[I'm also tempted to call this: The bollard as an urban safety agent]

Maybe return to questions of community ownership, control, maximising social control

Take seriously CPTED starting premises that the built environment (or infrastructure) is central to how people behave in cities, to the possibilities of social interaction and informal social control/surveillance

Yes! This first principles approach is a great idea to build the argument for a more holistic understanding of CPTED.

But begin to think afresh about what this means if we i) take seriously automobility as a source of harm and violence in cities and ii) think more capaciously about what urban safety means under conditions of ecological crisis – this requires not the wholesale critique of CPTED but an expansion of what might be entailed and involved in trying to take its premises and claims very seriously.

On bollards etc as moral architecture, embodiment of authority

Conclusion

Of some sort . . . but also maybe not needed

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Notes

Start with infrastructure because it gets us to the more than human character of the worlds we are trying to understand – the city. Replaces the human as the privileged epistemic subject and understands urban life through a distributed notion of agency
Buier the anthropology of infrastructure 49

What life worlds do such systems sustain or destroy (54)

Hansen and Schulze toward a material history of infrastructure

Start with relation between infrastructures and the physical environment – note that boundary between the two is illusory – acts on the environment – a force multiplier – but also then becomes part of the environment, or simply the environment – link back to chapter 2

Star, the ethnography of infrastructure

We need to study ‘the imbrication of infrastructure and human organisation

So the question is: What forms of human and human-material interaction are buried in the design/infrastructure of cities? What values, what principles of social ordering, what hierarchies, does it install?

380 – we need to attend to ‘the situations of those who are not served by a particular infrastructure

‘study a city and neglect its sewers and power supplied (as many have) and you miss essential elements of distributional justice and planning power. (379)

And one might add its roads

Infrastructure is:

Embedded – sunk into and inside other structures and social arrangements

Transparent – to use but invisibly supports or inhibits tasks – is both present and absent

Learned as part of membership; to use a city is to acquire a naturalised familiarity with its objects

Shapes and is shaped by the conventions of communities of practice – ie city dwellers

Sits on an installed base – on the sedimentary layers of cities

Becomes visible when it breaks

Nobody is really in charge

Infrastructure has a 'master narrative' (384) – a voice that speaks unconsciously from the presumed centre of things – *this voice is that of motorised vehicles* – to analyse it 'is to identify with that which has been named other, or unnamed

Knox the enchantments of infrastructure

Roads hold out a 'generic social promise' with the 'capacity to transform the spaces through which they pass'

Seem to promise – speed and connectivity; political freedom and economic prosperity (need to read Berlant on promises) – they have an 'illusory plausibility' (524) – roads triumph over the unstable forces and unruliness (525) – roads are part of the modern project of dominating the earth (527) – roads are part of the affective promise and engagement of modernity (534)

Why Road compression/LTNS etc seems like the breaking of a promise from the perspective of the motorist

They ask us to pay more attention to the 'situated moments wherein infrastructures impinge on social relations'

So I'm thinking this – in its own leaden footed way, CPTED was on to this. It got the infrastructural nature of cities as tangles of human, soil, matter etc. it saw human life as imbricated with its socio-material environment. It also got the most basic and forgotten part of urban criminology, even it itself forgot part of it. This is why it makes sense to start here – with Jacobs and Newman and building and the spaces between them. We can then intro social-spatial crim and fear of crime, and social cohesion as various iterations of CPTED caught up with them and ought to fold them into its concerns,

Larkin the politics and poetics of infrastructure

I = built networks that facilitate the flow of goods, people, or ideas and allow for their exchange over space. . . . they comprise the architecture for circulation. . . . they generate the ambient environment of everyday life

They also reveal forms of political rationality

'matter that enable the movement of other matter' (329); objects that create the grounds on which other objects operate

333 – for Benjamin one can never analyse the thing itself but must confront instead, one's own past, one's own desires, and the fantasies that stand as filters through which the object is seen,

Corchia and Borghini Infrastructure as a social category, JCS

Infrastructure – a substrate that supports something else, often acting as a foundation.

Helps us to call to attention the invisible, taken-for-granted material dimensions of social life

Political ecology of things – matter is not merely the passive object of human intervention but a dynamic and variable entity that actively shapes the conditions of human existence (how to work with this, without it being reductive, which they too easily assume)

Focus on their effects on natural environments – ‘become integral to the very ecosystems that they transform’ = helps us to question the illusion of an ‘endlessly available world’

‘the value of the concept of infrastructure lies in its ability to highlight the contemporary scope of the technological restructuring of physical space and the dispositional effects of infrastructure on everyday life’ (127)

Infrastructure ‘redefines the boundaries of the thinkability and realizability of our experiences in a largely artefactual world – it is a mode of organisation that actively does something – performs work in and on its environment – it does things with us, modifies our forms of life and everyday practices. – orients practice, forms habitus, structures fields of action

Foundation for everyday practice- enable, constrain, facilitate or block circulation – generative condition of both possibility and impossibility – orients us in the world in particular ways.

Also need to focus on power and how power it violence gets hidden in infrastructure. Shapes how it serves as a bridge or a barrier

Amin lively infrastructures

Part of a new genre of thinking that narratives the social life of a city through its material infrastructure. Built env/roads etc matters implicated in the making of urban functionality, sociality and identity

Infrastructure determines the character of urban well-being and sustainability; symbol power invested with progress and freedom, implicated in human experience of the city and shaping social identities

Analysis foregrounds the background to reveal the sociality of roads etc.

Degens et al analysing infrastructure in the Anthropocene

When assess and scrutinized infrastructures against different visions of the future., their order-forming elements, dysfunctionalities and transformation potential come to the fore – struggle over sustainability are struggles for the control and transformation of infrastructure. (10)(start with this).

infrastructures and practices co-evolve in mutually conditioning ways; ecological crises disrupt how people think about infrastructure (use in S 3) – we usually think about this in grand scale (flood defence – but matters in respect of the everyday ways in which infrastructures shape city life and daily movement – think about infrastructures relation to social organisation and moral order

(got to bring the questions raised in chapter 2 to this paper/chapter)

Latour After Lockdown

9- city is like termite mound – habitats and inhabitants are in continuity, to define one if to define to other. Its all one not an inanimate framework and those who animate it – if you cannot draw this boundary the idea of an environment ceases to make much sense (13)

20 – no one has ever had the experience of encountering ‘inert things’ – Qu – how does this obvious fact modify your ways of being, how you envision the future, of understanding freedom of movement (78)

Shove, infrastructures and practices

Makes a nice distinction between infrastructures-in-the-making and infrastructures-in-use

And focuses on the co-evolution of infrastructures and social practices.

—

C. Ray Jeffery, Crime Prevention through environmental design, 1971

[note how little of the book is in fact about the matter suggested by the title]

But does the conservative move of the time – away from social democratic/deep cause criminology to focus on ‘the ways in which the structure of the urban environment can be used to control and prevent crime’ (215)

Urban environments can influence crim beh in particular and beh in general in two ways – physically, by providing the physical surroundings to which individuals respond; and socially, by providing the social relationship to which individuals respond

'The physical characteristics of the urban environment are noise, pollution, overcrowding and refuge. The social characteristics are alienation, loneliness, anxiety and dehumanization. [*he could here be describing cities structured around car movement*]

He then pays quiet homage to Jane Jacobs who 'given us some good ideas from which we can start our analysis' (216) – busy streets are safe streets.

But he then makes the move that Newman also makes: 'Streets which have pedestrian and vehicular traffic, which have small shops and cafes open late at night, and which have residents living in apartments overlooking the street level are safe streets' (216)

So he too collapse pedestrian and vehicular traffic in ways that i) overlook the critique JJ makes of cars eroding cities, ii) fails to see the conflict between them, and iii) seems to assume that drivers can be eyes and ears – while remaining safe drivers.

He concludes: 'cities can be designed so as to increase human contact of an intimate nature. Anomie, loneliness and alienation need not characterise urban life' (225)

He's on to something here – in way that make surprising use of radical concepts coming from a conservative author. But he does not ask what features of the urban environment have contributed to these conditions and how they might be mitigated.

O Newman, Defensible space, 1972.

So, I am coming back to this book for the first time since the late 1980s, when I was torn as to whether it really was filled with the spirit of JJ, or some kind of conservative bastardisation of it. I now come to it all these years after puzzling over a question – where does the car and road infrastructure feature in Newman's account of the mid-20th century city, and of indefensible and defensible space

At first blush it seems more fixated on high rise housing than on what's happening on the ground. One index entry to automobile; none to roads

1-2 – 'it is clear to almost all researchers in crime prevention that the issue hinges on the inability of communities to come together in joint action. The physical environments we have been building in our cities for the past 25 years actually prevent such amity and discourage the natural pursuit of collective action'

What can he possibly mean? He means high rise. But these claims might equally refer to the building of car-centric cities in which i) movement takes place in cages making informal surveillance close to impossible, ii) the design of those cities disrupts the conditions of informal interaction and amity-building that Newman takes to be important. In both cases, it removes the confidence that he wants people to feel that they can know and feel able to question those who pass through the neighbourhood.

3 – ‘defensible space is a model for residential environment which inhibits crime by creating the physical expression of a social fabric that defends itself. Aim to create ‘an environment in which the latent territoriality and sense of community of inhabitants can be translated into responsibility for ensuring a safe, productive and well-maintained living space’ The potential criminal perceives such space as controlled by resident, leaving him as an intruder recognised and dealt with.

‘DS surrogate for a range of mechanisms – real and symbolic barriers, strongly defined areas of influence, and improved ops for surveillance – that combine to bring an environment under the control of its residents

Newman had big plans for re-making cities. He did not take physical infrastructure for granted. Si it is a genuine puzzle why this chain of thought did not lead him to car-centric mobility and the kinds of environments it requires, environments that seem to have the very properties and effects that he is describing and wanting to change.

Effects are direct – offenders can operate and get away in cars, are harder to notice and interact with. Cars insulate

And indirect – car-dominant environments interrupt possibilities for people to exercise influence over their living space. Cars insulate people from their (own) environments as they move through them

And long-term – ‘in our newly created dense and anonymous residential environments, we may be raising generations of young people who are totally lacking in any experience of personal or communal space and by extension of the personal rights and property of others. (4)

8 – need physical design that enables residents to control their environment rather than become its victims

[can I relate this to the effects of moving the police to cars]

15 big downer on gated middle class ‘high-rise fortresses of semi—luxury (14)

‘this introversion and intentional isolation inevitably occurs at the expense of the adjacent surroundings’

[we might say the same thing about the fear-fuelled resort to car travel over walking and public transit, where the car in effect serves as a mobile gated community]

The mental and physical withdrawal from the social order’ has three ‘dangerous attending characteristics’

‘indifference to the problem once it has been evaded’

Relegation of problem of security for formal authority alone

Resultant physical design of the buildings of our cities walling off housing complex (and one might add eyes and ears on the streets) 'are removed from all forms of social and visual contact.

'A natural mechanism providing safety to our streets (walking, cycling) has been sacrificed to ensure the security of the walled-off complex (or cocooned movement)

Secure buildings – like cars – 'achieve security at the expense of the surrounding area' (15). 'The street, without the continued presence of the citizen, will never be made to function safely'

An important principle of DS is creating space that allows residents to distinguish neighbour from intruder. (18)

The main target of the book is high-rise housing set apart from the city. But what also of the other modern form set apart from the city: the car. The book has only one apparent mention of cars – on pp 24-25

'another pet concept of the planner was to contribute to the undoing of those housing developments: the notion of the automobile superblock. In respect of the block 'it was taken for granted in the new plan that the intervening streets would be closed off, supposedly to make more open space. 'Erroneous on 3 counts'

'Most significantly, streets provide security in the form of prominent paths for concentrated pedestrian and vehicular movements; windows and doorways, when facing streets, extend the zone of residents' territorial commitments and allow for the continual surveillance of police in passing cars. Jane Jacobs in her *Death and Life of Great American Cities* contends that surveillance provided by casual passersby on foot or in a car is important as a deterrent to criminal activity' (p.25; emphasis added)

I'm pretty sure that Jacobs did not say that. Is this the moment when Newman makes an unannounced and barely noticed break with Jacobs by entirely overlooking all that she had to say about the destructive impact of cars on neighbourhood life and informal social control. Why he does this is interesting to speculate on. Was it wilful, or the result of barely conscious auto-centricity. It is nonetheless fateful.

He misses the critique of putting police in cars

He seems to know the importance of populated streets and public spaces, but no to notice the effect of cars and road infrastructure on informal surveillance

4 principles of defensible space:

The capacity of the physical environment to create perceived zones of territorial influence – mechanisms to reinforce territorial attitudes (or what one might call a sense of belonging)

The capacity of physical design to provide surveillance opportunities for residents and their agents – to casually and continually survey

The capacity of design to influence perceptions of a project's uniqueness – mechanism that neutralise stigma and reduce isolation

The influence of geographical juxtaposition with 'safe zones' on the security of adjacent areas.

1. Territoriality

What do we make of N's claim that people need an integral piece of land to defend?

Qu for him how to subdivide public space beyond home to give people sense of control over it? 'develop heightened sense of responsibility towards care of the environment and control of its penetration by others' (53)

The absence of car from N's analysis is striking in a number of ways: i) incomers shielded by cars are very difficult to identify and supervise; ii) there is no mention of road crime – or the impact of speed and volume of traffic on sense of belonging; iii) no sense of how cars interrupt the sense of public space as something over which residents have control. In much of this analysis cars sit there are inert objects; part of the background of urban life, which is especially odd when he seeks to bring so much else in urban design to the foreground and make it the object of critique and amelioration

In fact continues to believe that 'vehicular access provides a form of continuous natural surveillance, as well as an opportunity for formal patrol by a policing authority (p. 60)

But: i) can car traffic do the former? Seems to underestimate the impact of the shell on the driver's relation to the environments they travel upon. And do we really want drivers to be watching the sidewalks not the road – is this the advice; ii) seems unaware of the Kansas policing experiment or of the critiques of the distance the car placed between police and community.

Yet – speaks approvingly (pp. 61-3) of experiments that slowed traffic or completely closed portions of streets (to turn into a play area). (*what we would now call LTNs*). Concern for maintenance of safety of the street seemed to rise.

Also v supportive of symbolic and real barriers that mark out space as semi-private and under different social norms and regulation. (this will include measures to regulate traffic).

2. Natural surveillance

Essential that people feel that they can watch and have the authority to intervene. ; on lots of housing projects opp for informal supervision provided by passing cars and pedestrians is lost city police cannot enter grounds (unless of course they walk)

This collapsing of motorised and pedestrian supervision is v odd. How exactly is informal supervision by passing cars supposed to happen in terms of the criteria of effective supervision that Newman provides:

Developed sense of own proprietary rights (do drivers have this)

Activity occurring within the sphere of influence of the observer

Identification of the behaviour as being abnormal

Observers identification with victim or property

Extent to which observer feels they can alter the course of events (p. 79)

How can drivers (who will mostly be passing through) be able to supervise in any of these respects. This is so obvious why does N insist upon it?

3 image and milieu

Grid street patterns, with its constant flow of vehicular and pedestrian traffic, does provide an element of safety' (103). The huge project that closes off vehicular access 'has served to single out those areas and make them vulnerable'

It is noteworthy that N never makes any distinction between 'pedestrian and vehicular' traffic. He always runs them together and treats them and their purposes as the same. But how can they be? What happens if we make some important distinctions?

112 – downer on diverse use neighbourhoods – worry about schools, hamburger joints near where people live

204 – fundamental message is only effective measure for assuring a safe living environment is 'community control' -by manipulation of buildings and spatial configuration, one can create areas for which people will adopt concern, create conditions for mutual support

what would have happened to his analysis if he had folded into it road-crime and figures on the spatial distribution of road injury and death; if this has been part of the conversation about public safety?

If he had done so it would have been more difficult to write this sentence:

'the areas most usually identified as safe are heavily trafficked public streets and arteries combining both intense vehicular and pedestrian movement; commercial retailing areas during shopping hours, institutional areas and government offices.

Jane Jacobs, Death and Life of Great American Cities, 1961

17 autos often tagged as the villains responsible for ills in cities and disappointments of city planning. But the destructive effects of autos are much less a cause than a symptom of our incompetence at city building . . . planners don't know what to do with autos in cities because they do not know how to plan for workable and vital cities – with or without autos. The simple needs of autos are more easily satisfied than the complex needs of cities. How can you know what to do with traffic until you know how the city itself works, and what else to do else it needs to do with its streets'

So my sense is that post-Jacobs CPTED has taken up her ideas of the safety dividend of city streets, but disconnected them from her analysis of the erosion of cities by autos. Jacobs saw cars and paid attention to their destructive effects on cities – and by implication urban safety, even if she saw them as symptom of deeper failures of urban imagination. Her successors placed cars in the unnoticed background, so proceeded to think about urban safety without them. We need to register how much of a radical break that was, such that Jacobs and Newman cannot really be placed in the same sentence

Her target- the decentralists, those who wanted to spread and thin out cities, anti-city suburbanites

39 – streets and sidewalks, the main public spaces of a city, are its most vital organs

Key to understand cities – full of strangers; question of urban safety is how to feel safe and secure among all these strangers

41- first thing to understand is that public peace of cities is not first and foremost by the police. It is kept by an intricate, almost unconscious network of controls and standards set and enforced by the people themselves. Police cannot save you when casual enforcement has broken down.

The second thing to understand is that the⁴ problem of insecurity cannot be solved by spreading people out thinly – making cities into suburbs. 'a well used street is apt to be a safe street (44)

Requires: clear demarcation of public and private space, must be eyes on the street belonging to its natural proprietors, must have users on it fairly continuously; so needs facilities that draw people to the street. (46-7)

What do people do in the absence of such safety:

56 – they take refuge in vehicles (as people do in wild-animal reservations in Africa); technique of urban safety in LA (*note use of vehicles a crime avoidance strategy that*

reproduces the conditions that JJ thinks gives rise to urban danger in the first place). She places it in the same vein as 'the cultivation of a turf'

61 – order is the city is a kind of dance – an intricate ballet in which each has parts to play – which she then describes for Hudson Street.

So we need to do what CPTED does not – connect this to ch. 18, where she confronts the choice between the erosion of cities by autos or the attrition of autos by cities

352 – traffic arteries, parking lots, filling stations etc are 'powerful instruments of city destruction' to accommodate them city streets are broken down into loose sprawls, incoherent and vacuous for anyone on foot and so on.

But, she says, we blame autos too much; had they never been invented cities might have ended up much the same. It doesn't flow from the auto/transportation 'but from sheer disrespect for other city needs, uses and functions' (353)

Good transport is essential, a basic necessity. So the question is how to accommodate city transport without destroying the related and intricate concentrated land use'

So the problem is their over-abundance; has created an impasse between cars and pedestrians; but cannot solve this with separation; such conflict arises 'from the overwhelming numbers of vehicles, to which all but the most minimum pedestrian needs are gradually and steadily sacrificed' (359)

the problem 'is how to cut down drastically the absolute number of vehicles using a city' (358) – *where does this go on CPTED?*

The issue is not segregation but how to reduce the domination by cars and combat the erosion of sidewalks/play space; problem is one of absolute numbers.

So JJ's key question – 'erosion of cities by automobiles, or attrition of automobiles by cities' (363)

Erosion by cars – starts by nibbling then hefty bites, no single step crucial, but cumulative effect is enormous; more space given over to cars, the greater becomes the need for cars and hence still more space is needed. (365) reduces public transport, thins out uses, creates more need for cars – eg LA

'erosion, little by little, subtracts reasons for using the eroded district, and at the same time makes it less lively, less compact, less safe for those who continue to have reason to use it' (365) – the process then proceeds, with no stopping off point, becoming genuinely harder to halt or reverse.

To reverse this process requires attrition of autos by cities (373) – is unplanned but does occur' tells story of defeating Robert Moses, saving the park

Attrition operates by making conditions less convenient for cars (377); a steady, gradual process of reduction in the number of people using private vehicles; decrease the need (public transport) and convenience. – requires form of evolution, and small acts of taking back – ‘tactics of attrition’

Increase size of sidewalks/build-outs, public parks, using bollards to stop traffic runs off from arteries (381) so as to protect localised use of streets; truck/delivery only roads

384 – is we fail to stop the erosion of cities by cars? If we fail to take these practical steps? We will no longer need to ponder a mystery that has troubled men for millennia – what is the purpose of life? ‘The answer will be clear, established and for practical purposes indisputable: the purpose of life is to produce and consume automobiles’ (385)

Connect this to discussion on chapter 1. Connect car question to the urban safety question

Soomeren, Tackling Crime and fear of Crime through urban planning and architectural design

European Urban charter – basic right to ‘a secure and safe town, free so far as possible, from crime delinquency and aggression – road safety is presumably somewhere else

Aim rel of physical environment to crime and fear of crime and feelings of insecurity

235 – JJ overlook tow other lines of thought – assumes people will surveille, and offenders will take note

Is it a common problem of criminologists to partially read JJ – read only for public safety stuff, not the making of better cities; ignore ch 18 on cars and cities

237 – point of Newman to give people sense that ‘this is my territory’ – how do this in car-centric neighbourhoods, speaks to value of LTNs

249 – what is role of traffic in generating ‘fear generating locations’

Cozens ‘sustainable urban development and CPTED for the British city Cites 2002

This is an odd paper. It starts from the reasonable premise that sustainable urban development has neglected questions of safety and needs to take them seriously

SuD is environmental – best practice in management of energy, transport, waste and pollution

Social – greening of trade and services and enc personal responsibility

Economic – self-reliance and local equity

Cozens wants this agenda to recognise not posing a threat to current or future users has to include personal safety and fear of crime.

But the paper then becomes a CPTED paper – totally. The question of sustainable development evaporates – it become a takeover of sustainability by crime question

A better approach would be to think through crime prevention in relation to those three elements, r to think about what it means to do crime prevention in ways consistent with sustainability. Not a bit of it.

One way to do this might have been to ‘green’ the idea of ‘sense of ownership’ (and to fold in questions of environmental harm – road crime, pollution - into how that idea of cashed out.

Car also mainly features as a target – car parks etc, save for one brief reference to ‘thoughtfully locating entrances, exits, fencing, landscaping and lighting can direct pedestrian and vehicular traffic (which are like Newman treated as equivalents)

Armitage Sustainability v safety in Imagination for Crime Prevention

This is an odd paper – the oddness reflected in its title which pitches safety v sustainability. Safety here means burglary, not other types of crimes or any wider environmental safety. It could only have been written as if climate breakdown was not a thing.

She says the main issue here is that of ‘permeability or through movement of people and vehicles’ (83) (*this again conflates pedestrian and motorised movement, and odd re Newman who rails against buildings cut off from passing movement*)

The SBD/SCP view is that ‘properties should be designed with minimum access/egress and limited permeability’ (85) (does this mean a cul-de-sac)

In context of late 1990s sets up a contest between best crime prevention advice as set out above and the Dept of Environment transport and regions suggestions re housing lay out.

‘A user friendly public realm should make walking and cycling easy, pleasant and convenient, small blocks with pedestrian cut throughs and developments permeable and accessible to existing neighbourhoods’

Cf to SBD (87) – principles of maximising surveillance, minimise access and egress, and defensible space, increase physical security and territoriality – cites a pile of evidence in favour of each of this – key focus is on ‘property’s vulnerability to crime as viewed by an outsider’

Counterposes this to New Urbanism – traces this back to Jacobs, but cites not literature or evidence on this on its own terms.

She discerns two variants of it: neo-traditionalism, uses design to give people sense of community. Sidewalks, porches, community centres, foster interaction (King Charles version). Second version focuses on 'relation between land use and transportation' Modern suburbs had made people car-dependent which lead to pollution, obesity and other social ills. Planners recommend high density, compact, multi- use neighbourhoods – basically 15 minute cities.

Shared vision – walkability, connectivity, mixed use and diversity, mixed housing, density, high quality architecture

But evidence is crime is higher and costs of policing greater – see Knowles paper. Evidence is that 'greater levels of movement past the home are generally associated with higher degrees of risk'

This is a frankly bizarre paper – and a v good candidate for climate-breakdown complicit criminology!!

1. Elevates burglary risk to public problem number one and makes preventing this the barrier to all other aspects of sustainable living – so questions of pollution and climate get relegated and not mentioned. Even in its own terms was this focus made to look a bit silly by the subsequent falls in burglary across the modern world
2. Some forms of crime get no mention – notably road crime which is fostered by the forms of low-density crime that SBD encourages
3. No mention of wider environmental harms of low density living – pollution etc.

Burglary turns out to be quite the drug. Blinds it takers to a whole set of wider social ills. Excellent case in point of what happens when you insulate safe neighborhoods from the question of better neighbourhoods.

Crime friendly neighbourhoods – Reason

Free market attack on new urbanism which it claims sacrifices quality of life for 'the dubious goal of reducing auto dependency' – thinks the market for new urbanism is limited to young, single bohemian; all others prefer suburbs.

The claim about limiting permeability is I think a misreading of Newman who doesn't want places hidden away from public streets

There is her an odd reification of the cul-de-sac and the suburb, all of which rests on the harmlessness of the driving on which such low-density living requires

Crowe and Zahm CPTED Land Development 1994

Makes clear elements make a neighbourhood safe are also those that make it better.
Want to resist tendency to separate crime and fear of crime

Themes – natural access control, natural surveillance, territorial behaviour

‘major transportation arteries and the areas adjacent to them become part of an offender’s awareness space

So major traffic – as they hint – mean that home occupiers relinquish ownership of the front yard and street (and looks backwards) ‘making this territory available for ownership by outsiders’ (*this is a clear and arguably undeveloped point of connection with the livable streets literature*)

26 – neighbourhoods become vulnerable to crime when they are set up to produce anonymity – heavily travelled streets produce this effect while also giving rise to a lack of social control. So: ‘crime can be linked to the amount of itinerant traffic in the neighborhood.

Territoriality – sphere of influence which individuals exercise over a space and their sense of ‘ownership’

Seto et al. The new geography of contemporary urbanization and the environment

We have now entered the ‘century of the city’

Cities becoming bigger; urbanisation is happening faster, primarily happening in Asia and Africa; expensive and peri-urban; urban function is specialised

19 cities 10 million or more pop

172 – by 2025 80% of China and 50% of India will be urban; by 2030 one third of world’s urban residents will be in China or India

183 – challenge confronting the century of the city is not whether to urbanise but how to do so in ways that are sustainable and have less env impact

Cities becoming more expansive not compact

Braun and Randell, Post-Automobility futures

87 onwards on the nomos of automobility – a regime for the ordering of space; the speed and violence of AM has required the ‘massive appropriation and juridical transformation of space’ – creates a bracketed space inseparable from public and private life = an appropriation of the global commons – bringing under its control space that was previously outside of AM

Jose Pina-Sanchez – in defence of walkability as a crime prevention strategy

Notes opposition between new urbanism and crime prevention, especially the CPTED movement.

Develop a critique of Secured By Design – eg encourage car parking in front of houses and discourage footpaths. Cf Dutch secured by design.

Cf to Jane Jacobs who encouraged the safety dividend of encounter, CPTED worry about encounter and street (but not road) permeability (esp following Newman when means residents cannot recognise strangers) and promote enclosure – single-family, low-density cul-de-sacs. These disincentivise foot traffic and spending time outdoor, encourages car travel.

Thogh notes Newman (1996) was in favour of mini-neighbourhoods

J notes that this tends to over-represent crime from places where police more likely to get and people more likely to report. Low-density, secluded neighbourhoods have effects of increasing traffic offences across the road network.

But this policy also ignore effects on motor offending, and thereby has expanded number of motoring offences and its impact upon people's sense of a safe built environment.

Ignore effects of traffic on stress leading to violence; deterioration of built environment sending cues about non-enforcement of law, damage social connections that underpin informal surveillance and collective efficacy

[see Armitage and Cousins on all this]

So, the argument here aims to defend the idea that walkability is *for* crime prevention on the grounds that, once you factor in the effects on motor traffic of secluded, low-density cities, in terms of both motor offences and the indirect impact of car-centricity on urban fear and danger, walkable cities will be safer places. I am on board with this argument. But I have a residual worry which is that the argument risks making walkability a hostage of its crime preventative effects, and buying into the idea that crime is *the* determinant of how we think about place and mobility.

My complementary approach – I think it is complementary – is one that seeks to defend walkability *from* crime prevention strategies. By this I mean that walkability (or low-traffic neighbourhoods) may have all kind of effects in terms of air quality, sociality, kids play spaces, sustainability etc, that taken together make places better (more liveable, as the jargon has it), and the question of whether or not they have crime prevention benefits needs at least to be considered alongside these other effects, in the round, not taken to be a trump card. I know we are minded to think in crime and safety terms because we are criminologists, and the police because crime is their business. But there is a risk – as your account of Secured by Design illustrates – of separating the question of what makes streets or neighbourhoods safer from the question of what makes them better, and giving the former too much weight. So in the Secured by Design worldview crime too often becomes the enemy of sustainable mobility and livable neighbourhoods. Phineas Harper has some pointed thing to say about this -

<https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2022/may/02/police-public-spaces-secured-by-design-uk-cities>.

In sum, and I'm sure you get this, we need to find ways to think holistically, or ecologically, about the questions you raise in the paper in ways that makes crime prevention one, but only one, consideration and factors in motor traffic as a source of unsafety.

Cozens New urbanism, crime and suburbs Urban policy ad research

[what is puzzling is the degree of hostility on display towards new urbanism. Why? What explains this? Does to focus on crime simply bludgeon all other concerns away why does crime – in fact only some crime – burglary, get to acquire this privileged status in discourse on cities, to the extent that criminologists think it's okay to advise that we design places where people are unable to walk – and the crime critique gets called 'significant and far-reaching' (431)]

New urbanism claims to address many of the 'sustainability' issues facing society (why the scare quotes ffs) underpinned by slick; professional marketing campaigns.

Permeable streets 'mean more access for all citizens (including potential offenders) and increase opps for crime . By restricting access to areas there are fewer opportunities – walkable and accessible streets can increase opps for crime – need to up the level of 'intrusion difficulty' (433)

So – this is how it comes to be that criminologists think they can prevent walking – isn't this the logical of the gated community- what about road crime?

Wants New urbanism to embrace CPTED so communicates be safer and sustainable. But never asks if CPTED needs to embrace sustainability – or to think about hat it means to think about urban safety in a climate emergency if NU 'must consider the evidence on crime and fear of crime' must CPTED consider the evidence of global warming

Permeability increases opps for crime shows 30 years of crime – (so does freedom, so has the car)

Opposed to rear lanesways

Safest place for car in a private garage in the house

CPTED – aim to design to promote territoriality and sense of ownership (436) – 2nd generation aims to promote social activities and diversity

Qu – other than defending homes – what does CPTED want neighbourhoods the city to look or feel like – how does it work unless its builds in car dependency

Cozens – Urban planning and environmental criminology

481- notes aim to investigate the 'urban stage' where crime is located

482 – permeable neighbourhoods, mixed-use and higher densities can come into conflict with safety from crime – also wants to treat freedom from crime and violence as indicator of sustainability – see summary quote on p. 496

483- defensible space is space capable of being defended – but also defended from cars?

‘a range of mechanisms; real and symbolic barriers; strongly-defined areas of influence; and improved opps for surveillance, that combine to bring an environment under the control of its residents (Newman 1973: 3)

[surely car structures have a bearing on this question) – cfs with indefensible space – ‘incapable of being defended by residents, and offensive space, taken over by others for own criminal purposes (what happens here if you make a distinction between streets and roads – is the failure to do so part of the problem?)

488 – Brantingham’s on the ‘environmental backcloth’ (note the stage metaphor again) – but the car creates more than a backcloth – its is active on the scene.

490 – note the enclosure v encounter model – But what happens when you separate road from street connectivity – do LTNS do both?

492 – SBD advocates minimum permeability – except by car – promotes ‘non-permeable cul-de-sac layouts

496- you suspect that not enough has attention been paid here to difference between heavy pedestrian and heavy vehicle flows

Cozens and Love (2015) review of status of CPTED

Jacobs – clear demarcation between public and private space; must be eyes on the street; sidewalk needs continuous users. Cf Newman needs sense of ownership and control; not just use.

Territoriality – use real and symbolic barriers to create sense of proprietary concern

Surveillance – built form must offer opps for surveillance by residents

Image and milieu – capacity of design to influence perception of space to promote well-ordered spaces

Geographical juxtaposition – the capacity of surrounding areas to influence the security of adjacent areas (is road infra crucial here)

Ownership, community and responsibility

1st generation CPTED

7 principles: territorial reinforcement, surveillance, image management, access control, legitimate activity support, target hardening

2nd generation – of community or social CPTED

4 concepts – social cohesion, community connectivity, community culture, community participation, threshold capacity (neighbourhoods have finite carrying capacity for certain activities and land uses!!! – can I use this idea) – beyond this they have tipping points where functionality of neighbourhood is affected

Also look at Brantingham, Clarke etc on:

Crime – generators, attractors, detractors, facilitators, precipitators

[has CPTED here just bled into socio-spatial criminology and its concerns with social disorganisation, social capital, informal social control and collective efficacy]

Territorial reinforcement = collective efficacy

Natural surveillance = informal social control

Natural access control = ??

Can I do something with the carrying capacity and tripping points idea?]

405 – acknowledgment of the conflict – connectivity advocates about reduce car use, congestion, and pollution – ‘their position does not necessarily relate to crime reduction’ Hmm. [speaks to problem of the crime/harm separation]

See Cozens ‘Dark side’ paper – crime prevention at the expense of creating sterile public spaces absent of public sociability

There is now 2nd and 3rd generation CPTED. 2nd generation folds into questions of community cohesion and building making it hard to set apart from Sampson-eque urban criminology. 3rd generation is really a greening of CPTED bringing crime and safety into questions about liveability, sustainability and public health (See Mihiniac and Saville paper in Social Sciences). But much of this still reads the city as absent of traffic

In fact, question of CPTED to sustainable communities and wider quality of life issues – see Cozens and Love and Armitage SI of Built Environment, though this article still sees congestion, pollution, car-dependency etc as parallel to crime and fear, because the latter do not include motor crimes.

But there is here a question about what happens to the encounter v enclosure debate if ones makes a distinction, which these authors generally do not, between road and street connectivity. So, for example, closing roads to cars may be a form of enclosure (encourages ownership, keeps a certain form of stranger movement out) while enabling encounter that is face-to-face.

Schneider and Kitchen – crime prevention and the urban environment

Org idea that we might manipulate the macro and micro environment to reduce opps for crime

Do we need with Clarke to think about settings or situations

Repeats the canard (p45) that new urbanism is nostalgic, anti-urban, small town focused – pine for ‘lost community values of bygone eras’. *It is not – it’s a different vision of dense cities. Maybe better not to focus it on the proximity revolution and 15MC*

Then reviews the evidence – all very crime focused, practically set in isolation.

Chapter 5 on history of ALO in UK

Browning et al. ‘Human mobility and crime’ Annual Review of Criminology

[this is a weird paper. Its focus is mobility but it has a flat/substantively empty conception of how people get around and their conditions of possibility, meanings and effects]

This is despite it's opening call for 'acknowledgment of the often submerged assumptions regarding mobility embedded on several prominent criminological theories' (100)

So notes that social disorganization and collective efficacy approaches 'imply the importance of mobility for the emergence, reinforcement, and effective application of informal social control norms within urban neighbourhoods' (103) – quite – but collapses different forms of movement into 'mobility' – how is it possible to imagine that this is analytically helpful

Makes same point about disorder theories – mobility processes implicated in the presence of people on the street that signal local social indifference (so much methodological innovation hiding key conceptual bluntness)

Lanfear – collective efficacy and the built environment

Coll efficacy works over the long term to prevent the building of environmental features that provide criminal opps

Important to note that potentially criminogenic features of the urban environment also serve noncriminal purposes (providing reason to keep the after and better in conversation and not let one mode of city making crowd out the other)

Coll efficacy theory has been silent on the built environment

Kinney et al Crime attractors, Built Environment

Are these helpful ideas:

Activity nodes pull large people towards them are crime generators; some pull in people with criminal motivations – crime attractors. Some areas push people away – crime detractors

Is key here to attract people while reducing/controlling criminals – its about the kind of attraction/detraction

Appleyard and Lintell the environmental quality of city streets

Maybe start with this late 1960s study in SF of effect of traffic on the quality and social interaction on city streets – why did this occur in ignorant parallel universe to the development of CPTED? Was it the path not taken?

Study of heavy moderate and light trafficked roads

Heavy – continuous presence of strangers, even in autos, ‘evinced some feelings of fear’ (87) heavy street deemed unsafe on heavy street no clear demarcation between public territory and local territory that was respn of locals

Heavy street – had little or no sidewalk activity used solely as a corridor between individual homes; residents kept to selves no sense of community. Failed to notice and remember the detailed physical environment around them

‘residents struggled to retain some feeling of personal identity in their surroundings (93) – sense of personal territory did not extend onto the street – cf light and moderate (94) – diff between ‘territorial restriction and expansiveness – heavy traffic associated with withdrawal from the physical environment (97)

Note also – individual and family adjustments to their deteriorating environment was muted because no clear public target for their resentment, only the individual automobiles and trucks (99)

When we think about traffic we need to think about environmental standards

‘what about standards that will allow people to feel comfortable on sidewalks, or to cross the street, which encourage neighbourliness, allow privacy and an ample sense of personal territory, or which promote care and interest for the physical environment of the street (100)

Driven to excess Hart and Parkhurst

Replicates Appleyard’s study of the 1969 in Bristol – qu what motor traffic does to neighbourhood life, picks 3 streets low, medium and high traffic volumes – (get original and liveable streets revisited)

Origin study shows traffic produces ‘significant erosion of social capital’ (why was this work not known to Newman and early CPTED folk) people on heavy traffic streets had one-third fewer social connections

P . 4 see famous map

Lists impact of traffic on health, water and air quality and social networks

Heavy traffic street – poor air quality irritant; children on street rendered ‘invisible’

Restricted sense of ‘home territory’ – ‘area over which you feel you have some sense of personal responsibility or stewardship (Appleyard 1969 – asked the very question that so interested Newman). In heavy traffic street shrinks to home and garden; light traffic extends to the street . .

Gossling – why cities need to take road space from cars

Cars take up space – when it car is driven at 50kph it needs 70 times more space than a pedestrian or cyclist. Parked car need 10 times more space than a bicycle.

Car space unfair and inefficient from social, health, environmental and econ point of view

But to tackle need to understand it functions are not just instrumental but symbolic and affective. Status, power socializing control etc – see his book on this *The Psychology of the car*

Need to tackle the central criminological irony of the car – it satisfied a psychological need to feel safe and secure, while undermining the safety and security of its non-users – which most of the time is most of us.

So need to look for ways to dissolve driver-vehicle bonds

Bosselmann and O’Hare, Traffic in urban American neighbourhoods: the influence of Buchanan

Buchanan 1963 intro idea of ‘environmental areas’ ‘pedestrians safe from the hazards of through traffic’ – had influence until highway building programme

Taken up by Appleyard – all streets resident mainly concerned by dangers of traffic – social interaction and feelings of neighbourliness vary inversely with traffic levels (again parallel path to work on urban crime and disorder)

Challenge for planners – aim to then had been to facilitate traffic, talk now to manage it [key pint here – make neighbourhood traffic management into a crime prevention tool/idea.

Do by limit amount; affect behvioir of drivers – control traffic speeds and volumes

Cf protection (double glazing etc) and amelioration (compensate)

Do by positive physical controls; passive/soft controls, psycho perception

See also woonerf – shared space

